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Space Race 2: USA vs. China

by Burt Burlington

Under the blue logo, the people at NASA call the meatball, chaos was about to ensue. Deep inside the Kennedy Space Center, on Merritt Island, Florida, there was the famous Operations Center. A windowless room, only illuminated by expensive-looking screens. There were hundreds of screens, small, big, and even bigger. The screens showed many important rocket-scientific things. Tens of NASA employees, armed in their blue polos and khaki sand pants, habited the Operation Center. All hard at work at bringing spaceships up. Another job the employees had was to bring them down as well.

Large doors swung open, and every khaki-pantsed employee popped their heads up from behind their pcs like a family of meerkats. The man who entered was Edward Duke, leader of the Uppermost Space Association, or USA. A conservative big red tie around his chubby neck and boring square glasses like one of the screens. With his outfit, he sported an American flag pin as big as a flat hand, and a razor-sharp buzzcut, showing that he was meant to be taken seriously. Making his way to a large metal table in the middle of the Operations Center, he throws off a stack of seemingly important pages and some people's lunch. A

resounding loud echo catches every meerkat's reaction when Duke hits the table with his closed fist.

“China is at it again,” he said solemnly.

The employees look at each other confused, unknowing what China did this time.

“Frank, pull it up,” Duke said without looking at whoever “Frank” was.

Frank, another khaki-pantsed-blue-polo-wearing-NASA-employee with black hair, one beard, and one glasses, stood up from a pc before Duke. Walking at his own comfortable pace, Frank passed Duke, who was leaning down on the metal table looking down. Nothing else but Frank's meandering footsteps could be heard when making his way to the large central screen in the Operations Center. Frank turns a comically small dial on the wall beside the 310-inch screen.

A zap and up pops a live feed of the lunar landing site we landed on o' so long ago. Yet, this time the famous American flag was difficult to see behind the slightly larger Chinese flag that was waving a few feet in front.

“The Chinese have done the inexcusable,” Duke said, “We have to show that America is still the best country on the planet and exceed what we did in ‘69.”

Duke looks around the room, his employees staring at them through their big glasses.

“So, does anybody have any ideas?” Duke looks around but interrupts the thinktank session, saying, “and I want to preface, we don't want to start World War 3.”

After some muttering, brainstorming, and the picking up of lunches thrown onto the ground, one man is brave enough to speak.

“Maybe if we go up and just plant a big-.”

“I swear to god, if you are suggesting planting a bigger flag in front of theirs, I am gonna shoot you into the sun.”

The employee falls quiet. The only thing that can be heard is the sound of people opening their lunchboxes that were thrown onto the ground. The tension in the room is

indistinguishable from when the Apollo rocket first launched, and nobody knew if it would crash or not.

Duke looks around the room, staring down every past University of Houston, Maryland, and Harvard student.

“Come on, people! It’s not rocket science!” Duke yells.

A silence ensues.

“But, it is?” A quiet voice points out in the back.

“I know that!” Duke growls.

The growl only creates more fear amongst the khaki-pantsed.

“We can nuke the moon?” utters a whimpering voice behind a computer.

Duke looks down and frowns, “what?”

“Well, Elon Musk suggested it for Mars to harbor life, and he is quite smart.”

Rabble ensues between the employees. People agree with the assessment, and employees repeat it. “Elon Musk is quite smart, yes,” with multiple NASA employees accepting the statement.

“No!” Duke interrupts the bandwagon Musk fans, “we’re not gonna nuke the Moon.”

“We can be the first country to have sex in space!” an employee yells.

Lifting his square glasses, Duke pinches between his eyes, almost taking out his eyes because of the nature of the idiotic suggestion.

“No, we can’t.” Duke says. “And we’ve tried. What else do you think miss Universe and mister Universe are for?”

“Why not?” a sad voice says in the back.

“Because we can’t get our dick up in space, look it up,” Duke says, annoyed.

“Also, we ain’t gonna win a fertility contest against the Chinese; those people are fertile as Iowa’s black gold fields in April.”

The employees are silenced by Duke's facts and logic. He pinches his eyes and sighs while leaning on the table. The other employees sit down or look at the floor, defeated.

The impressive National Aeronautics and Space Administration of the United States is hopeless to save their country. Until someone comes up with a plan...

"We can kill the Chinese!" an employee shouts.

"What did I say about starting a third World War!" Duke yells, "we are not Germany, goddammit." Duke looks around the room. His eye finds a man wearing a blue polo, an Alpine head, and khaki lederhosen. It is an older man with small round glasses.

Duke looks at the man, worried. "I am sorry, Klaus."

Klaus adjusts his glasses, which look like they got grabbed straight off Heinrich Himmler's face.

"Nein tak-en," Klaus says with a smile as feeble as porcelain German milk boy statue.

Duke nods appreciatively, but when he looks forward, his gaze is frozen. He stares at an American flag on the Operations Center's dark wall. A yellow light shines on the flag, creating a circular canvas around the US flag. Confused NASA employees slowly turn to what Duke is staring at, their khaki's popping and squeaking. Everyone is looking at the stars-and-stripes, red, white, and blue, freedom-loving, star-spangled-banner, American flag.

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It was a warm and moist day in the humid month of August in Florida. But the NASA employees and Duke, standing at the bottom of the tall white Vehicle Assembly Building, didn't mind the heat, because they were proud. The blue meatball looked down at them alongside the fitting, vertical American flag painted down the VAB. The sky was brilliant dark blue, and the sun just went under.

The employees and Duke looked up at the sky with a satisfied smile, a moon-landing-times-ten-satisfied smile.

“We did it, people; we saved America,” Duke says, still staring at the sky.

The Moon stands at its zenith in the sky, as round and sharp as ever before, and a beautiful white glow shines down on Earth. Yet some of its gorgeous light is obscured by an equally gorgeous twenty-one thousand square American flag, wrapped around the equator of the Moon.

The employees – and the rest of mankind, they imagine – look upon the Moon in awe at this milestone America set for humanity.

A tear started to envelop in the corner of Duke's eye, seemingly feeling the same euphoria as if George W. Bush called him “A real American.” Together they stood in astonishment at their brilliantness for hours.

The following evening, Duke rolls out of his stars and stripes bedsheets. He wants to take another look at their feat of engineering. Passing a printed-out copy of the Declaration of Independence and a hill of fireworks meant for the Fourth of July in 11 months, Duke makes his way to the window.

Standing at the window in his white sleeveless shirt and red, white, and blue socks, he leans in to look at the Moon. But his eyes whiten, and his face loses color as if he has seen a ghost.

On the other side of the globe, in the beautiful tropical paradise of Liberia, people enjoy late-night strolls on the beaches. The red and white striped Liberian flag, with its famous singular star, hangs outside beach cabins and is also printed on surf planks. The people look up at the Moon, which is passed its full moon phase and into its waxing gibbous phase. The American flag has faded, and the blinding sunlight that stretches around the Earth reveals a magnificent Liberian flag.

As the people of Liberia party, singing the national anthem of their motherland continuously till the Moon sets that evening, we can still hear a distinct patriotic scream across the Atlantic.